

neurodivers³

Masking Recovery Pack

Recovery Days: The First 48 Hours.

For the slump after a heavy mask day — the crash nobody else saw.

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How this pack works

Three-step use

1. Pick the protocol that matches the day.
2. Do the lowest-input version.
3. Log the pattern later, if you can.

What this is / isn't

- This is not a plan for never masking again. I do not think that is realistic, and I do not want to sell you a fantasy where every social, work, family, or public situation becomes safe overnight.
- This PDF is for the after. The slump. The delayed crash. The day where you looked fine and then paid for it when nobody was watching.
- Use the protocol that matches the kind of day you had. Leave the rest. The Notion tracker can wait until you have more capacity.

Worth remembering:

If all you do is read one message template and send it, this pack worked. That counts. Recovery is not a performance.

What a masking hangover can feel like

What the cost can feel like once you stop.

Body crash

heavy limbs, sudden tiredness, feeling like you have been unplugged.

Word loss

not being able to explain, reply, or make language arrive.

Irritability

everything feels too close, too loud, too much.

Sensory intolerance

inputs that were barely manageable earlier become impossible.

Identity blur

not knowing what you wanted, meant, liked, agreed with, or performed.

Disproportionate tiredness

the event was "normal", but the cost is not.

Delayed processing

the feelings arrive hours later, sometimes all at once.

If you can function in the moment and collapse later, the collapse is still data.

The first 48 hours

What to do, hour by hour.

First 2 hours

- reduce inputs
- remove decisions
- hydrate/feed if possible
- get out of performance clothes
- stop explaining.

Same day

- cancel what can be cancelled
- lower the communication load
- reduce sensory friction
- choose one safe input
- do not replay the whole day yet.

Next day

- keep plans soft
- do the practical minimum
- avoid turning recovery into a performance review
- use scripts instead of original wording.

48 hours later

- log the pattern if you have capacity
- notice what helped
- notice what cost the most
- choose one adjustment for next time.

Recovery is not wasted time. It is the cost becoming visible.

Protocol: after a high-mask work day

Work recovery protocol

1. Change sensory state: clothes, light, sound, posture.
2. Remove one demand from tonight.
3. Send one boundary message if needed.
4. Do not immediately analyse how you came across.
5. Pick one safe input and repeat it.

MESSAGE TEMPLATE

I am running on very little capacity after today, so I am going quiet tonight. Nothing is wrong between us. I just need the low-input version of the evening.

The demand I can remove tonight

The safe input I can use

The message I might send

Protocol: after a social day

Social recovery protocol

1. Take off the performance costume.
2. Lower sound and light.
3. Do not replay every sentence yet.
4. Send a "home safe / going quiet" text.
5. Allow parallel company if being alone feels worse.

MESSAGE TEMPLATE

I had a good time and I am very done now. I am going quiet for the rest of the day, but I am glad I came.

What I need less of

What I need more of

Who might need a simple message

Protocol: after a family event

Family recovery protocol

1. Name the role you got pulled into.
2. Separate guilt from capacity.
3. Decide what not to answer tonight.
4. Use a pre-written boundary.
5. Let the old version of you be loud without obeying it.

MESSAGE TEMPLATE

I am not able to keep talking about this tonight. I am going to stop here and come back to it another day if I have capacity.

The role I got pulled into

The topic I am not answering tonight

The boundary I need

When you cannot tell what was yours

Gently separate performance from preference.

Masking can make your own preferences go quiet. This page is not here to interrogate you. It is here to gently separate performance from preference.

What did I agree with that I do not actually agree with?

What did I laugh at that did not feel funny?

What did I say yes to because it was easier?

What did I hide because explaining would cost too much?

What preference came back when I was alone?

What did my body know before I did?

What would I choose if nobody needed me to be easy?

Permission slips for the after

Tear-out reminders. No reason required.

**I am allowed to recover from things
other people did not notice.**

**I am allowed to cancel the optional
thing.**

**I am allowed to stop explaining while I
am dysregulated.**

**I am allowed to need quiet after being
"fine".**

**I am allowed to count the cost even
when I coped.**

**I am allowed to use scripts instead of
original words.**

I am allowed to answer tomorrow.

**I am allowed to be proud of surviving
and still admit it hurt.**

What to log later

Bridge to the Notion tracker.

Do not log the pattern while you are still inside the crash. Later is fine. Later is often better.

*The Notion template is for the pattern.
This page is the bridge.*

Where was I?

Who was I with?

Which mask came online?

What did it cost?

What helped me come back?

What would I change next time?

What signal did I miss?

When this is bigger than one recovery day

When the pattern needs more than a self-help pack.

Signs the pattern may need more support:

- recurring crashes
- dread before ordinary events
- losing speech or skills more often
- increasing sensory intolerance
- not recovering between demands
- avoiding more of life because the cost is too high
- feeling like there is no unmasked place to land.

This pack is not therapy. If professional support would help, you deserve access to it. If you are in immediate danger or feel unable to keep yourself safe, contact local emergency services now. In the UK, call 999 or 112 in an emergency. For free listening support in the UK and Ireland, Samaritans are available on 116 123. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. Outside these countries, use your local emergency number or a local crisis line; if you are unsure where to start, findahelpline.com lists support by country.

Needing more support is not a failure of the worksheet.

Before you go

Where this fits

Mask Load Tracker

The Notion template to spot the pattern over time.

neurodivers3.co.uk/store

Burnout Recovery Roadmap

If this is bigger than masking hangovers.

neurodivers3.co.uk/store

Sensory Audit Workbook

If the environment is part of the crash.

neurodivers3.co.uk/store

Autistic Masking essay

The long-form story behind this pack.

neurodivers3.co.uk/blog

About neurodivers³

neurodivers³ is a home for honest stories, practical tools, and ideas for making everyday life work better with a neurodivergent brain. I make resources for late-diagnosed and self-identified neurodivergent adults who are tired of being told to try harder at systems that were never built for them. This resource is not a clinical tool. It is a practical one. Use what helps; leave what does not.

— Ollie

Feedback invitation:

If a protocol helped, or if you'd word one differently, I'd genuinely like to know. Reply any time at hello@neurodivers3.co.uk.

Refundable for 14 days, no questions. Email hello@neurodivers3.co.uk within 14 days of purchase.